IGNOU MPCL-007 Viva Questions & Answers

Experiment: Memory Span

Objective: To study the span of immediate memory (digit span, letter span, or word span).

1. What is the aim of the memory span experiment?
To determine the capacity of immediate memory — how many items a person can recall correctly after one presentation.

2. What is meant by memory span?
The maximum number of items that can be recalled immediately and correctly after one presentation.

3. What type of memory is tested in this experiment?
Short-term memory (STM) or immediate memory.

4. Which method is used in this experiment?
Method of serial recall.

5. What is the typical digit span for adults?
7 ± 2 items (George A. Miller).

6. What factors affect memory span?
Type of material, meaningfulness, attention, age, intelligence, and interference.

7. Who proposed the concept '7 ± 2'?
George A. Miller (1956).

8. What materials are used?
List of digits/letters/words, stopwatch, data sheet, pen/pencil.

9. What is the procedure?
Digits/letters read at 1 per second, subject recalls, series length increases until recall fails; longest correct series is memory span.

10. What type of recall is used?
Immediate serial recall.

11. What is the difference between digit span and word span?
Digit span uses numbers (easier), word span uses meaningful/unrelated words (harder).

12. Difference between STM and LTM?
STM stores briefly (seconds), LTM stores for long period (lifetime).

13. Average letter span?
Around 6 ± 2 items.

14. What is rehearsal and its effect?
Repetition of items mentally; improves recall and memory span.

15. Conclusion?
Immediate memory has limited capacity; performance varies by material and individual.

Material Type	Memory Span
Digits	7
Letters	6

Words	5

Applications: Useful in cognitive assessment, learning, and clinical psychology.

16. What happens to memory span with distraction?
It decreases as attention divides.

17. How does age influence span?
Improves till adulthood, then may decline.

18. How can it be improved?
Chunking, rehearsal, attention, and association.

19. What is chunking?
Combining items into larger meaningful units (e.g., 1947–2000).

20. Significance?
Demonstrates capacity limits of short-term memory; basis for cognitive models.